



NASA blasts off 3D Printer

SpaceX Dragon blasted a 3D Printer off to the International Space Station earlier this month <http://dgit.in/3DPrinterInSpace>



GIFs on your wall

If you want to put up animated photograph and graphics over your wall, you have Canviz <http://dgit.in/Canviz>



Every month we highlight some aspiring tech writers and their spirited attempt to get published in the magazine. Let's have more!

Media streamers and buying advice



Praneet Sah

How to avoid being fooled

Ever have it happen to you that your laptop labelled "Intel i7 inside" runs slower than another laptop with the same label? If yes, then you're not the only one. The fact is that companies generally hide the full name of that specific component. And it's not just the case with computer processors – this is true regardless of whether it's something as simple as a RAM stick or as costly as a graphics card. So you must be thinking: "How can they cheat?" Well, they aren't actually cheating. All that these companies did was present their products in attractive ads starring your favourite celebs, compelling you to buy the product. So it was your fault, really.

Don't get taken for a ride

The next question on your mind must be: "How can you deal with it?" First and foremost, NEVER believe what the salesmen say. Keep in mind that the core purpose of his job is to make a sale. If you don't follow this advice, reading the article further won't fetch you anything. A few months ago, we bought a laptop from a store where the salesmen pointed to a range of laptops and informed us, "All of these are i7 laptops, you can pick any of them. They're equally powerful." Strange, considering that the prices varied from ₹50K to 80K. At that moment, a normal customer would have simply picked up the 50K model under the assumption that it's equivalent in performance to the 80K model. But that's not true. Let's see why, beginning with the processor.

Differences in processors

In the i7 series itself, there are dozens of different models and each of them has some performance differences. As of now, for laptops there are two processors which are quite popular: the i7-4700MQ and the i7-4702MQ. Both of them are being used in high-end laptops, but which one is more powerful? You'll never know because companies generally don't even specify the exact model numbers! They'll simply leave you with a "Powered by Intel i7" logo. Although they both look almost the same, the fact is that the 4700MQ outperforms the 4702MQ model by a small margin. The 4702MQ is more power efficient, while the 4700MQ is more of a performance beast. So now that you're aware, always check the exact model number and do your research before purchasing.

Differences in graphics cards.

The next component is the graphics card and here we'll be referring to graphics cards used in desktops. Even in the selection of GPUs, the fault lies with the customers, more specifically their

perceptions. What some users generally do is they simply find the best GPU for their need – let's say the Radeon R9-290X – and then purchase it. Once again, you may be compromising on a better performing component, available at the same cost. To explain it simply, think of the Radeon R9-290X as the batter for your cake. This batter is purchased by/distributed to different companies, who do the baking and serve it to you under different names and at varied prices; for example, the chipset R9-290X is available in the market branded as 'Sapphire R9-290X' or 'Powercolor R9-290X' or 'Gigabyte R9-290X' among other names. The actual ingredients can vary, resulting in some variants being better than the other.

Sorting through these GPU variants might be hard for the novice, so spend some time on forums and other websites and read up reviews on the options available.

Differences in RAM sticks.

Another such component is your RAM stick. You've probably been asked, "How much GB of RAM does your computer have?" While the amount of "GB in your RAM" is a big deal, speed matters just as much. Generally, nobody cares about the speed and buys the cheaper option, which obviously has less speed. This is partly what makes your memory-intensive applications run slow. The RAM speed isn't noticeable in games/applications and better RAM would make a performance difference of only 3-5 percent. However, if you're a hardcore user with tons of tabs open in programs such as Firefox or Google Chrome, consuming about 1-2 GB of RAM, the speed of the RAM will matter. Also make sure that your RAM is compatible with the motherboard you're using since not all speeds are supported by all motherboards.

The list doesn't end here. There are tons of other products that you should research carefully before buying, such as your internal hard disk drives; companies generally advertise only their capacity, while the speed, which is just as important, is left unmentioned. A 1TB internal HDD with 5200 rpm of speed won't be as fast as a 7200 rpm drive of the same capacity. As I've advised before, find the products' exact model numbers and then Google them. Now, an important thing to keep in mind here is to ensure that there's no overkill, which generally happens while upgrading your desktop. If you have a slow processor, then getting a RAM of very high speed will serve no purpose, as would be the case for a high-end graphics card. So before every purchase, do your homework well and then spend smartly.

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